REPO RADAR

# Penpot: the free, open-source Figma alternative

A short setup and decision guide from the Repo Radar video "This Free GitHub Repo Replaces Figma (Penpot Tested)".

## What it is

- **Penpot**: an open-source design and prototyping tool that runs in the browser.
- Made by **Kaleidos** (Madrid, Spain). First alpha: February 2, 2021 (unveiled at FOSDEM 2021).
- License: **Mozilla Public License 2.0** (MPL-2.0). Repository: github.com/penpot/penpot (about 62K stars when we checked).

## What we verified in the sandbox (Nov 4, 2026)

- The shallow clone took about 10 seconds and is about 500 MB on disk.
- The `LICENSE` file is the Mozilla Public License 2.0.
- `docker/images/docker-compose.yaml` lists 8 services: Penpot frontend, backend, exporter, admin console, MCP server, plus Postgres 15, Valkey 8.1 and Mailpit.
- **Not verified:** the full stack was not started (no Docker engine in our sandbox), so we did not test a live server.

## Three ways to use it

1. **Hosted:** create an account on penpot.app. The Professional plan is listed at $0.
2. **Self-hosted with Docker:** follow the official self-hosting guide on penpot.app, which covers Docker, Kubernetes and Elestio. The compose file lives in `docker/images/` in the repository.
3. **Read the code:** frontend, backend, exporter, plugins and the MCP server are all in one repository.

## Price check (public price pages, Nov 2026)

| Plan | Listed price |

|---|---|

| Figma Professional | $16 full seat, $12 dev seat, $3 collab seat, per month |

| Figma Organization (annual) | $55 full seat, $25 dev seat, $5 collab seat, per month |

| Penpot Professional | $0 |

| Penpot Unlimited | $7 per editor per month, capped at $175 per month |

Example for 10 full seats, one year, listed prices: Figma Professional $1,920; Figma Organization $6,600; Penpot Unlimited $840; Penpot Professional $0.

Your plan, team size and taxes will differ. This is a comparison of public prices, not advice.

## Three things to do

1. Open the hosted plan and import or rebuild one small screen to feel the editor.
2. Check CSS Grid / Flex layout and design tokens on a real component.
3. Before you move a team, list the Figma plugins you depend on.

## Two mistakes to avoid

- Assuming "free software" means zero effort: self-hosting means running a database and a mail service.
- Moving everyone at once. Pilot with one project first.

## Glossary

- **MPL-2.0:** if you change Penpot's own files and share your version, you share those changes too. You can still use it at work.

- **Design tokens:** colors, spacing and type sizes stored in one place that designs read from.
- **MCP server:** a connector that lets AI tools talk to your designs.
- **Self-hosting:** running the software on your own server.

## Sources


- https://github.com/penpot/penpot
- https://penpot.app/pricing
- https://www.figma.com/pricing/
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Penpot


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